People with Mobility Impairments

- Always ask the person how you can help before beginning any assistance. Even though it may be important to evacuate quickly, respect their independence to the extent possible. Don't make assumptions about the person's abilities.
- Ask if they have limitations or problems that may affect their safety.
- Some people may need assistance getting out of bed or out of a chair, but CAN then proceed without assistance. Ask!
- Here are some other questions you may find helpful.
  - "Are you able to stand or walk without the help of a mobility device like a cane, walker or a wheelchair?"
  - "You might have to [stand] [walk] for quite awhile on your own. Will this be ok? Please be sure and tell someone if you think you need assistance."
  - "Do you have full use of your arms?"
- When carrying the person, avoid putting pressure on his or her arms, legs or chest. This may result in spasms, pain, and may even interfere with their ability to breathe.

- Avoid the "fireman's carry." Use the one or two person carry techniques.

Crutches, Canes or Other Mobility Devices

- A person using a mobility device may be able to negotiate stairs independently. One hand is used to grasp the handrail while the other hand is used for the crutch or cane. Do not interfere with the person's movement unless asked to do so, or the nature of the emergency is such that absolute speed is the primary concern. If this is the case, tell the person what you'll need to do and why.
- Ask if you can help by offering to carry the extra crutch.
- If the stairs are crowded, act as a buffer and run interference for the person.

Evacuating Wheelchair Users

- If the conversation will take more than a few minutes, sit or kneel to speak to the person at eye level.
- Wheelchair users are trained in special techniques to transfer from one chair to another. Depending on their upper body strength, they may be able to do much of the work themselves.
- Before you assume you need to help, or what that help should be, ask the person what help they need.

Carrying Techniques for Non-Motorized Wheelchairs

- The in-chair carry is the most desirable technique to use, if possible.
  - **One-person assist**
    - Grasp the pushing grips, if available.
    - Stand one step above and behind the wheelchair.
    - Tilt the wheelchair backward until a balance (fulcrum) is achieved.
    - Keep your center of gravity low.
    - Descend frontward.
    - Let the back wheels gradually lower to the next step.
  - **Two-person assist**
    - Position the second rescuer in front of the wheelchair and face the wheelchair.
    - Stand one, two, or three steps down (depending on the height of the other rescuer).
    - Grasp the frame of the wheelchair.
    - Push into the wheelchair.
    - Descend the stairs backwards.

Motorized Wheelchairs

- Motorized wheelchairs may weigh over 100 pounds unoccupied, and may be longer than manual wheelchairs. Lifting a motorized wheelchair and user up or down stairs requires two to four people.

- People in motorized wheelchairs probably know their equipment much better than you do! Before lifting, ask about heavy chair parts that can be temporarily detached, how you should position yourselves, where you should grab hold, and what, if any, angle to tip the chair backward.

- Turn the wheelchair's power off before lifting it.

- Most people who use motorized wheelchairs have limited arm and hand motion. Ask if they have any special requirements for being transported up or down the stairs.